Shadows of Kanchi — Story Bible

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Premise

Logline: A proud young temple guard breaks a sacred seal to win the king's favour, shatters the Shadow Mirror, and turns his kingdom to stone. With only his own living shadow as a guide, he must climb through cursed temples, stepwells and foundries to undo his mistake, knowing that success will erase every trace of what he did.

- **Genre:** 3rd-person action-platformer with environmental puzzles and light combat, in the line of *Prince of Persia: The Sands of Time*.
- **Setting:** Vel Nadu, a fictional kingdom inspired by the Chola empire, around 1000 CE. Granite temple towers, bronze foundries, stepwells, river ports.
- **Tone:** Mythic adventure with warmth and wit. Moments of awe and grief, never grimdark.
- **Length:** Prologue, 5 chapters, epilogue. About 3–4 hours.
- **Visual style:** PS2-era low-poly, warm sunset palette, deep blue-violet shadows.

Game pillars

1. **Traversal is the puzzle.** Every room asks "how do I get across?"
2. **Light and shadow are the rules.** The hero's power only works where shadows fall, so moving light sources changes the level.
3. **The story is told by the hero.** He narrates, and when you die he says "No, no, that's not how it happened."
4. **Every chapter teaches one new trick,** then tests it with everything learned before.

The world: Vel Nadu

Vel Nadu is a river kingdom at the height of its power, and its capital Kanchi is about to crown a new king. Everything in the game happens in a single day: the coronation morning, frozen by the curse.

History

- 300 years ago, the founding sage-architect Mayan carved the **Nizhal Kannadi** (the Shadow Mirror) from black obsidian. It holds every shadow the kingdom has ever cast, and with them its memories and its time.
- The Mirror was sealed at the top of the **Mirror Temple**, a 13-storey granite tower. Only the king may look into it, once, on his coronation day.

- Legend says the Mirror can "give back what was lost." Nobody living knows what it costs.

Regions of Kanchi (each is one chapter)

Region	What it is	Look and feel
Royal Palace	Coronation courtyards, roofs, banner ropes	Gold, marigold garlands, morning sun
Kalyani Stepwell	A vast flooded stepwell beneath the city	Green water, mossy steps, shafts of light
Bronze Foundry	Where the kingdom casts its bronze statues and war machines	Furnace orange, molten channels, giant gears
Thousand-Pillar Hall	Library and star observatory	Moonlight, palm-leaf scrolls, sundials
Mirror Temple	The sealed tower at the city's heart	Black stone, violet sky, floating rubble

The curse

When the Mirror shatters, every person's shadow is torn away. People without shadows turn to stone mid-step, and the city is filled with statues frozen in celebration. The torn shadows become **Nizhalars**, hungry shadow-creatures that want bodies again. The sun stops at noon and will not move.

The power system

The hero holds a shard of the Mirror, so his shadow is torn free but stays loyal and alive. He can use it to:

1. **Shadow Step** (Ch. 1): teleport into any shadow on the floor within range. Moving lamps and doors changes where you can go.
2. **Shadow Anchor** (Ch. 2): leave the shadow behind to hold a lever or weigh a plate while you move on.
3. **Shadow Strike** (Ch. 3): attack from inside a shadow. The core of combat.
4. **Light Bend** (Ch. 4): rotate mirror shards to throw new shadows across rooms.
5. **Eclipse** (Ch. 5): briefly darken the whole room, turning every surface into a path. Limited charges.

The rule that matters: in full sunlight with no shadow nearby, the hero is just a normal man. Every puzzle is about creating or finding darkness.

Characters

Ilan (Ilanthiraiyan), the hero, 20

- **Who:** The youngest guard of the royal temple. Son of a stone-carver who died building the Mirror Temple's outer wall, so he grew up climbing temple towers and knows how they are built.
- **Want:** To be seen. He wants a title, a place in the court, and his name carved in stone like the kings.
- **Need:** To learn that what matters is what you do, not who remembers it.
- **Flaw:** Pride, and the impatience that comes with it. Acts first, thinks later.
- **Strength:** Fearless, quick, funny under pressure, deeply loyal once he trusts someone.
- **Look:** Lean, bare-armed, red waist sash, bronze armband with the shard set into it, a short curved blade.
- **Voice:** Cocky narrator early on ("I was the best climber in Kanchi. Ask anyone."), quieter and more honest by the end.

Nizhal, Ilan's living shadow

- **Who:** Ilan's own shadow, torn free but held by the shard. A silhouette with two glowing violet eyes. Speaks in Ilan's voice, a little deeper.
- **Role:** Companion, power source and conscience in reverse. He says aloud the selfish things Ilan is thinking.
- **Secret:** Nizhal is slowly gaining his own will. He wants to stay free forever, and the only way is for the Mirror to stay broken.
- **Gameplay:** He *is* the power system. His mood shows in the HUD: calm violet when loyal, red when he's scheming.

Kayal, the mirror-keeper, 19

- **Who:** Daughter of the Mirror Temple's head keeper, trained in the old astronomy and the lost lore of the Mirror. She survived the curse because she was underground in the stepwell when it hit.
- **Want:** To save her father, who is frozen at the temple doors.
- **Personality:** Sharp, patient, dry humour, doesn't trust Ilan at first and is right not to.
- **Skills:** Archer with a short bow. Can read the old Grantha inscriptions that hold puzzle clues. In combat she pins enemies; in puzzles she shoots ropes and distant switches.
- **Arc:** From distrust to partnership. She is the one who tells Ilan what the Mirror really costs.

Kaalavan, the Royal Minister, villain, 55

- **Who:** The old king's most trusted advisor. Brilliant, calm, respected.

- **Motive:** His daughter died in a famine 20 years ago. He has spent his life searching for the Mirror's power to "give back what was lost." He believes that if the Mirror holds every shadow ever cast, it holds her too.
- **Plan:** He tricks Ilan into breaking the seal (only someone of the carver's bloodline can open Mayan's door). Then he uses the shards to pull his daughter's shadow back into the world, even if every living person stays stone.
- **Why he works:** He's not evil for fun. He's what Ilan could become: someone who can't let go.

Supporting cast

Character	Role
Prince Aditya	The heir being crowned. Ilan's childhood friend turned distant royal. Frozen in the courtyard; restored at the end.
Keeper Sendan	Kayal's father. Appears in stone, and in shadow-memories that teach lore.
Mayan the Architect	Long-dead creator of the Mirror. Speaks through carved murals and a final shadow-memory.
Valli	Kaalavan's daughter. Seen only as a small shadow-girl in visions. The heart of the villain's story.

Enemies

- **Nizhal Walkers:** basic shadow-soldiers, slow and grabby.
- **Leapers:** fast, wall-climbing shadows that chase you on walls.
- **Lamp-bearers:** carry light that destroys your shadow powers. Kill them first.
- **Bronze Guardians:** possessed foundry statues, immune until you strike from shadow.
- **Bosses:** the Stepwell Serpent, the Bronze Colossus, Kaalavan, and finally Nizhal himself.

Ilan's character arc

Ilan moves from "I want to be remembered" to "I'll do the right thing even if no one ever knows." Each chapter breaks one false belief, and his shadow Nizhal is the voice of the belief he's leaving behind.

Stage	Chapter	What Ilan believes	What breaks it	How he changes
1. The proud boy	Prologue–Ch. 1	"If I do something great, they'll finally see me."	His great deed destroys the city.	Shock and guilt. He decides to fix it, mainly to clear his name.
2. The lone fixer	Ch. 2	"I don't need anyone. I caused this, I'll fix it."	He nearly drowns and Kayal saves him.	He accepts help, grudgingly.
3. The partner	Ch. 3	"Together we can fix it and be heroes."	Kayal tells him every hero in the murals is forgotten; the Mirror erases whoever restores it.	Fear. He secretly hopes to find another way.
4. The tempted	Ch. 4	"Maybe there's a way to win without losing anything."	Nizhal offers it: keep the Mirror broken, rule the shadow-city. Kaalavan offers the same choice in a different form. Kayal is captured because Ilan hesitated.	He sees himself in Kaalavan, a man who can't let go.
5. The guardian	Ch. 5–Ending	"What I do matters more than who remembers."	He chooses to restore the Mirror and give up his shadow.	Quiet, steady, whole. No longer needs to be seen.

How the arc shows in play, not just cutscenes

- **Narration shifts.** Early death lines are cocky ("I'd never fall for that."). Late ones are gentle ("No. Kayal was waiting. I got up.").
- **Nizhal's colour.** Violet when Ilan trusts himself, drifting red as temptation grows in Ch. 4.
- **Optional statue moments.** Ilan can stop beside frozen citizens. Early he ignores them; later he says their names, which he learns from shadow-memories.

- **Combat style.** Early animations are flashy and show-off; the final chapter's are tight and protective, positioning to cover Kayal.
- **Final gameplay choice.** In the last fight the player must let Nizhal go, dropping the power they've used all game. The mechanic delivers the theme.

Supporting arcs

- **Kayal:** distrust → respect → she's the one who chooses to remember him. Her secret fear is that she is useless without her father's guidance; she learns she already knows enough.
- **Nizhal:** loyal tool → independent voice → rival. He is not purely evil. He's afraid of being nothing again, just as Ilan was afraid of being nobody.
- **Kaalavan:** a mirror of Ilan's future. In his final moment he lets his daughter's shadow go, giving Ilan the example he needs.

The story, chapter by chapter

Prologue: The Last Morning (about 10 min)

Opening shot: an older Ilan sits by a river at dusk and says, "Most people think the coronation of Prince Aditya was an ordinary day. I'm going to tell you what really happened."

Coronation morning. Ilan races across palace rooftops to deliver a message, teaching run, jump, wall-run and ledge grab. He's late and overlooked, standing at the back while the prince he grew up with is honoured. Minister Kaalavan finds him and says quietly: the new king will be cursed unless someone retrieves the Mirror for the ritual, and only a carver's son can open Mayan's door. "Do this, and your name goes in stone."

Chapter 1: The Coronation of Ash (Royal Palace, about 35 min)

- **Story:** Ilan climbs the Mirror Temple's outer face and solves Mayan's door, a rotating stone-relief puzzle. Inside, he lifts the Mirror. Kaalavan, behind him, strikes it with a bronze rod. It shatters. A wave of darkness rolls over Kanchi. Every shadow tears free, people turn to stone, and the sun stops at noon. Ilan wakes on the temple steps with a shard fused into his armband. His shadow stands up by itself and says, "Well. You've really done it this time."
- **Learn:** Shadow Step. Escape the palace by stepping between shadows cast by banners, elephants frozen mid-procession, and swinging lamps.
- **Key puzzle:** Cut ropes to drop silk canopies, creating shadows to cross a sunlit courtyard.

- **Boss / set piece:** Escape a wave of Nizhal Walkers through the collapsing coronation hall.
- **End beat:** Ilan sees Aditya frozen in stone with the crown half-raised. Guilt lands. Nizhal: "Nobody saw it was you. You could just walk away." Ilan doesn't.

Chapter 2: The Drowned Stepwell (Kalyani Stepwell, about 40 min)

- **Story:** The shards scattered when the Mirror broke, and the nearest fell into the great stepwell. Ilan descends alone, refuses to think about needing help, and gets trapped as water rises. An arrow pins the rope he's falling past. **Kayal** pulls him out. She knows exactly who he is: "You're the fool who opened the door." They agree to work together, with no trust.
- **Learn:** Shadow Anchor. Leave your shadow on a pressure plate to hold water gates open.
- **Key puzzles:** Raise and lower water across nine levels of steps. Kayal shoots ropes to create bridges; shafts of light make some areas no-go.
- **Boss:** The **Stepwell Serpent**, a giant shadow-snake made of the drowned. Flood and drain the arena to expose it to light.
- **End beat:** First shard recovered. Kayal reads a carving: "The one who mends the Mirror gives it his shadow." She keeps it to herself for now.

Chapter 3: The Bronze Foundry (Foundry District, about 45 min)

- **Story:** The second shard is in the foundry, where possessed bronze statues guard it. Ilan and Kayal start to trust each other. Banter and a quiet campfire scene where Ilan admits he did it for glory, and Kayal admits she's afraid she can't finish her father's work. Then a shadow-memory of Mayan reveals the truth: whoever restores the Mirror is erased from every memory, and loses their shadow forever. Kayal knew. Their first real fight.
- **Learn:** Shadow Strike. Bronze Guardians can only be hit from inside a shadow.
- **Key puzzles:** Redirect molten bronze channels to cool and harden into new platforms; time the furnace glow, which kills shadows, on a rhythm.
- **Boss:** The **Bronze Colossus**, a 30-foot war statue. Climb it like a level, step through the shadows of its own limbs, strike its glowing core.
- **End beat:** Ilan says he'll still do it, but privately tells Nizhal to find him another way. Nizhal's eyes flicker red for the first time.

Chapter 4: The Thousand-Pillar Hall (Library and Observatory, about 45 min)

- **Story:** The final shard is in the observatory. Here Nizhal openly offers his deal: leave the Mirror broken, and Ilan can rule a city of shadows where he's the only one who matters. Ilan hesitates for a moment too long, and Nizhal uses the moment to lead Kaalavan's shadow-army to them. **Kayal is captured** and carried to the Mirror Temple. Kaalavan, now glowing with shard-power, explains himself: he wants his daughter Valli back, and the world can stay stone. "You and I are the same, boy. We just want what we're owed."
- **Learn:** Light Bend. Rotate polished bronze mirrors and sundial gnomons to throw shadows across the hall.
- **Key puzzles:** A giant star-map floor that you rotate to align constellations; a sundial room where you move the sun's beam to make a path of shadow.
- **Boss:** A duel with Kaalavan's projection in a hall of moving pillars. You can't win; it ends with him leaving with the shard.
- **End beat:** Alone, Ilan finally sees himself in Kaalavan. Narration: "I'd spent my whole life wanting what I was owed. Nobody owed me anything." He heads for the Mirror Temple.

Chapter 5: The Mirror Temple (The Tower, about 50 min)

- **Story:** Ilan climbs the 13-storey tower, which now floats in pieces in a violet sky. Each floor shows a shadow-memory from Kanchi's past, reminding him of the ordinary people he'll save. At the top he frees Kayal mid-fight. Kaalavan has rebuilt the Mirror and pulls Valli's small shadow from it, but she won't come to him. She's afraid of the father he became. Broken, Kaalavan lets her go back into the Mirror, and turns to stone.
- **Learn:** Eclipse. Briefly darken whole rooms to open every surface.
- **Key puzzles:** Rotating tower floors; combine all five powers in a final gauntlet.
- **Final boss: Nizhal.** He takes his own body from the darkness and fights with all of Ilan's powers. Phase 1: shadow vs. shadow. Phase 2: Kayal lights torches and you fight in full light, as a normal man. Phase 3: the player must choose to release Nizhal into the Mirror. The power bar empties for good.
- **End beat:** Ilan places the last shard. Light floods out. Everything rewinds to the coronation morning.

Ending, themes and narrator

Epilogue: The Man Without a Shadow

The coronation morning plays again, as if nothing happened. Aditya is crowned. Kaalavan is in the crowd, older and quieter; he leaves the court that day without a word. Nobody remembers the curse. Nobody remembers Ilan.

We return to the opening scene: older Ilan by the river at dusk. The camera pulls back and reveals who he has been telling the story to all along: **Kayal**, now the Mirror's keeper. She says, "It's a good story. Hard to believe." He smiles and stands to leave. As he walks into the sunset, the camera holds on the ground: **Ilan casts no shadow.**

Final beat: Kayal looks down at the ground where his shadow should be. A small, knowing smile. She remembers. Cut to black.

Themes

- **Being seen vs. doing right.** The whole arc. The reward for the hero's sacrifice is that no one knows it.
- **Letting go.** Kaalavan can't release his grief; Ilan learns to release his pride, and his power.
- **The shadow self.** Nizhal is the part of us that wants to be special at any cost.
- **Ordinary people matter.** The statues, the shadow-memories, the names Ilan learns.

The narrator device

- The whole game is Ilan telling the story to Kayal, which explains why the hero can talk over gameplay.
- **On death:** "No, no, wait. That's not how it happened." and you restart at the checkpoint. It turns failure into part of the story.
- **Loading screens:** short lines from Ilan's narration that hint at puzzles.
- **Kayal interjects** occasionally ("You're making yourself sound very brave."), a payoff hint before the final reveal.

Sequel hook (optional)

In a post-credits shot, a single small shard glints at the bottom of the Kaveri river. Somewhere, a shadow moves on its own.

Prompts for concept art and writing

Use these to generate concept art (Midjourney, Higgsfield, etc.) and to expand scenes with an LLM. Keep the same style suffix on every image prompt so everything looks like one game.

Style suffix (add to every image prompt)

```
PS2-era 3D game screenshot, low-poly models, 256px hand-painted textures, warm sunset palette, deep violet shadows, slight fog, Chola-dynasty South Indian temple architecture, cinematic third-person camera, no text
```

Characters

- **Ilan:** `Lean 20-year-old South Indian temple guard, bare arms, red waist sash, bronze armband with a glowing black obsidian shard, short curved sword, confident grin, full-body character turnaround sheet, front side back` + style suffix
- **Nizhal:** `Living shadow silhouette of a young warrior, pure black body with soft smoky edges, two glowing violet eyes, standing beside its owner, character sheet` + style suffix
- **Kayal:** `19-year-old South Indian temple keeper and archer, braided hair with jasmine, indigo and gold saree adapted for movement, short bow, palm-leaf scroll satchel, calm sharp expression, character turnaround sheet` + style suffix
- **Kaalavan:** `55-year-old royal minister of an ancient South Indian kingdom, grey beard, silk angavastram, gold rings, holding a bronze rod, calm and sorrowful eyes, glowing obsidian shards orbiting him` + style suffix

Environments

- **Royal Palace:** `Coronation courtyard of an ancient Tamil kingdom frozen in time, citizens turned to grey stone mid-celebration, marigold garlands, war elephants frozen, sun fixed at noon` + style suffix
- **Kalyani Stepwell:** `Enormous flooded stepwell with nine levels of geometric stone steps, green water, moss, beams of sunlight from above, rope bridges` + style suffix
- **Bronze Foundry:** `Ancient bronze foundry, rivers of molten bronze, giant wooden gears, half-cast bronze statues, furnace glow, a 30-foot bronze war colossus` + style suffix
- **Thousand-Pillar Hall:** `Hall of a thousand carved granite pillars at night, palm-leaf manuscript shelves, a rotating star-map floor, giant sundial, moonlight` + style suffix
- **Mirror Temple:** `13-storey Dravidian vimana temple tower broken into floating pieces in a violet sky, black obsidian mirror glowing at the summit` + style suffix

LLM prompt for expanding scenes and dialogue

```
You are the lead narrative designer for "Shadows of Kanchi", a PS2-style action-platformer inspired by Prince of Persia: The Sands of Time, set in a fictional Chola-era kingdom called Vel Nadu.

Story bible: [paste this document]

Task: Write the full script for [CHAPTER / SCENE].
Include:
1. Scene setting and camera direction
2. Dialogue for Ilan, Nizhal and Kayal (Ilan narrates in past tense; Nizhal speaks Ilan's selfish thoughts; Kayal is dry and sharp)
3. 3 narrator lines for death/restart moments that fit Ilan's current arc stage
4. 2 environmental puzzle ideas using the power(s) unlocked so far
5. Lore inscriptions Kayal can read on walls
Rules: keep lines short (under 15 words), no modern slang, keep the tone mythic but warm.
```

LLM prompt for level design

```
Design a level for "Shadows of Kanchi" chapter [N] in [REGION]. The player has these powers: [list]. Give: a top-down room-by-room layout (8–12 rooms), the traversal challenge in each room, where light sources and shadows fall, one optional collectible, checkpoint locations, and the order in which the new power is taught, practised and tested.
```